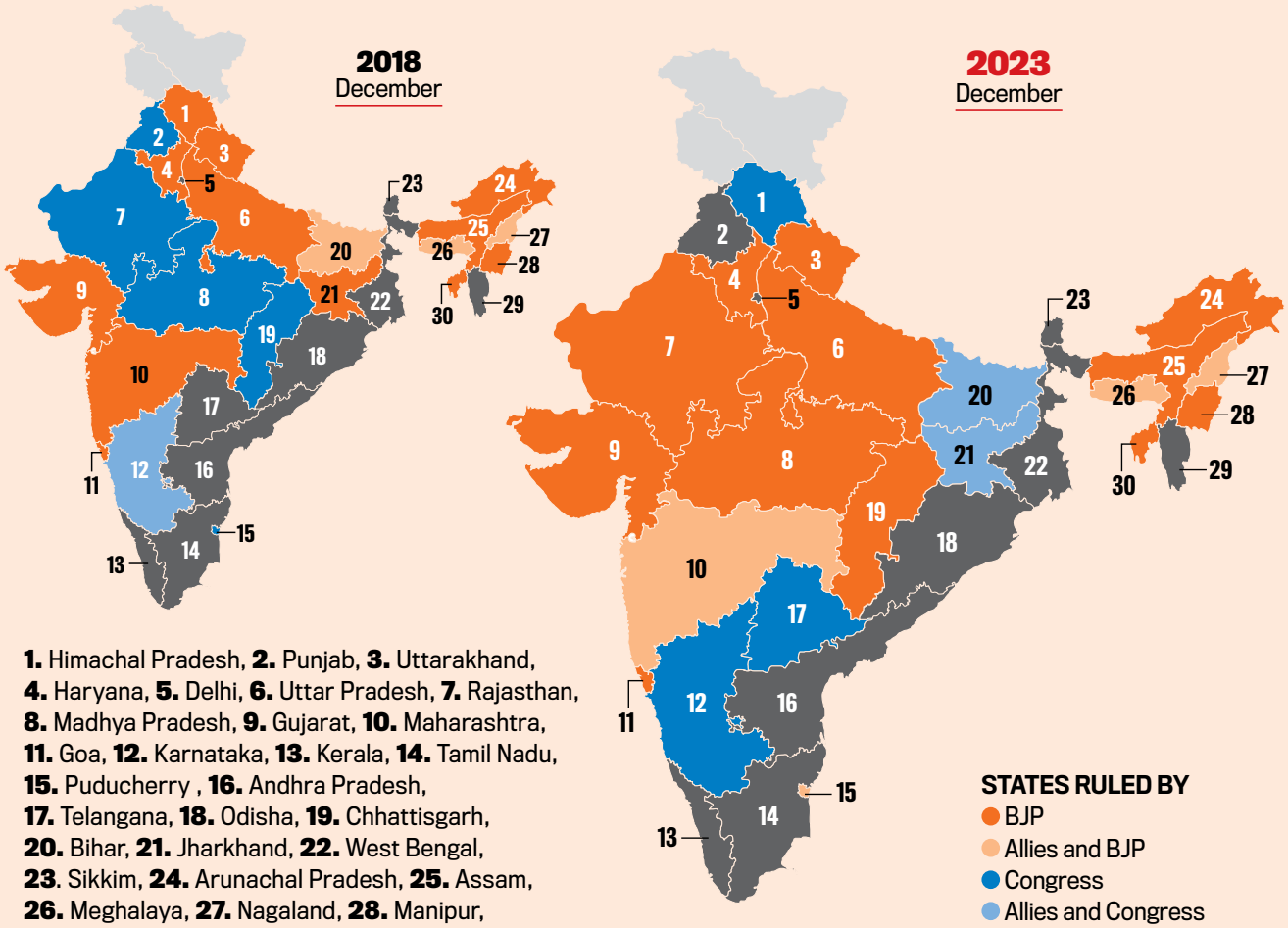
THE HEARTLAND BOOST

IN THE RUN-UP TO THE 2024 LOK SABHA ELECTION, THE BJP HAS CONSOLIDATED ITS HOLD IN THE HINDI BELT, COMPARED TO FIVE YEARS AGO. BETWEEN 2018 AND 2023, IT LOST ONLY TWO SMALL STATES–JHARKHAND AND HIMACHAL PRADESH–BUT GAINED THREE KEY ONES–RAJASTHAN, MADHYA PRADESH AND CHHATTISGARH



got down to work. They crafted a battle plan that would, in one fell swoop, demolish all threats standing in the way of the saffron party's quest for greatness. The mistakes in Karnataka had been an object lesson for the party and the top brass. Replacing chief minister B.S. Yediyurappa with Basavaraj Bommai a year before the polls appeared to be an unwise move in hindsight, for which the party paid a heavy price. They were caught flat-footed when the Congress announced a string of guarantees, which they listed on innovative 'guarantee cards', a strategy that fetched them votes and propelled them to power. In a post-poll analysis of its debacle in the state, the BJP discovered that the party had failed to connect with the voters (especially the beneficiaries of its social sector schemes) because of poor governance, deep factionalism, ineffective leadership and inflation.

FIVE-PRONGED OFFENSIVE

Learning from these costly oversights, the BJP approached elections in the three northern states with five broad strategies. The first involved countering Congress state satraps like former chief minister Kamal Nath in Madhya Pradesh, chief minister Ashok Gehlot in Rajasthan and his counterpart Bhupesh Baghel in Chhattisgarh, who were spearheading the respective campaigns in their states. Rather than pit just one face against these strongmen, Modi and Shah decided to exert their combined might, presenting voters with a collective leadership that included both state heavyweights and central leaders, including Union ministers. The party got these individuals not just to help in the campaign but fight elections, too, in some cases. That strategy found maximum play in

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